

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 3
THE VEDIC CULTURE (1500BC-600BC)

MIGRATION OF THE ARYANS

The Aryans (peoples speaking Indo-Aryan language) were semi-nomadic pastoral people and originated from somewhere in the grasslands stretching from southern **Russia to Central Asia**. They might entered India through **Khyber Pass** (in Hindukush Mountains) around 1500 BC.

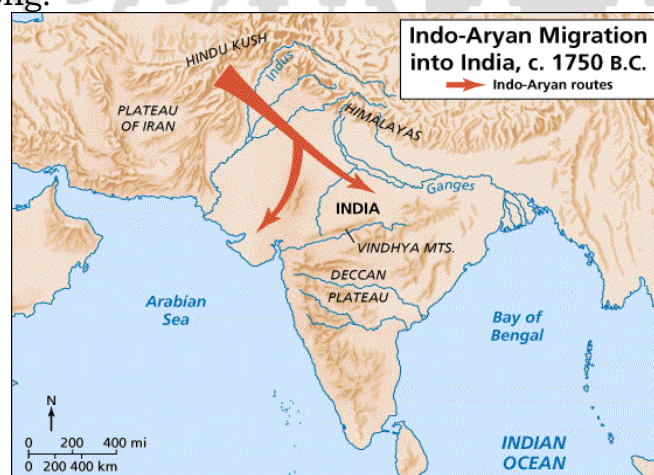
The holy book of Iran '**Avesta**' has similarities with Rigveda indicate a shared Indo-Iranian linguistic and religious heritage. The Aryan people came in **several batches** spanning several hundred years. Meanwhile the interaction between the indigenous inhabitants and the newcomers continued. One of the important results of this process of interaction was that the Vedic form of the Aryan language became predominant in the entire **North-western** India. The texts composed in this language, as mentioned above, are popularly known as the **Vedic Texts**.

GEOGRAPHICAL HORIZON OF THE VEDIC ARYANS

The early Vedic Aryans lived in the area known as **sapta-sindhu** meaning area of seven rivers. This area largely covers the **north-western** part of **South Asia** up to river Yamuna. The seven rivers included:

RIG VEDIC NAMES	MODERN NAMES
SINDHU	INDUS
VITASTA	JHELMUM
ASIKNI	CHENAB
PURUSHNI	RAVI
VIPASH	BEAS
SHUTUDRI	SUTLEJ
SARASVATI	GHAGGAR

In this area the **Rigvedic people** lived, fought battles, grazed their herds of cattle and other domesticated animals. Gradually moving eastward, they came to occupy eastern **U.P. (Kosala)** and **north Bihar (Videha)** during the Later Vedic period. Here they came into contact with the people who spoke languages different from their own and were living in this area for long.



THE RIG VEDIC POLITICAL ORGANISATION

The chief social unit of the Aryans was known as jana. The chief of this unit was the political leader called **rajan**. The main function of the chief was to protect the jana and cattle from the enemies. He was helped in his task by the tribal assemblies called **sabha, samiti, vidatha, gana and parishad**.

Out of these sabha and samiti were the most important assemblies. All aspects of life were discussed in these assemblies. These may include wars, distribution of the spoils of wars, judicial and religious activities etc.

Thus these assemblies in a way limited the powers of the chiefs. Interestingly, women were also allowed to participate in the deliberations of the **sabha and Vidatha**. The tribe generally elected him. Though the succession in one family was known but that was not based on the rule of primogeniture (i.e., the eldest son acquiring the position).

The **purohita** assisted and advised the **chief on various matters**. Other than the **purohita**, there were a limited number of other officials who assisted the chief in the day-to-day tribal affairs.

Senani, gramani, etc. are some of the functionaries which find mention in the Rigveda. The sena or army was not a permanent fighting group and consisted of able bodied tribesmen who were mobilized at the time of the wars. **Takshan**, the carpenter and **rathakara**, the chariot maker was responsible for making chariots.

There is no official mentioned as a collector of taxes. The people offered to the chief what is called **bali**. It was just a voluntary contribution made by the ordinary tribesmen on special occasions. All this shows that the early Vedic polity was an uncomplicated system based on the support and active participation of all the tribesmen. This situation, however, changed during the later Vedic phase.

POLITICAL CHANGES IN THE LATER VEDIC PHASE (1000 BC-500BC)

The changes in the material and social life during the later Vedic period led to changes in the political sphere as well. The nature of **chiefship** changed in this period. The territorial idea gained ground. The people started to lose their control over the chief and the popular assemblies gradually disappeared.

The chiefship had become hereditary. The idea of the divine nature of kingship gets a mention in the literature of this period. The brahmanas helped the chiefs in this process. The elaborate coronation rituals such as **vajapeya and rajasuya, aswamedha** established the chief authority.

All these lived on the taxes called **bali, the shulka, and the bhaga** offered by the people. The chiefs of this period belonged to the **kshatriya varna** and they in league with the brahmanas tried to establish complete control over the people in the name of dharma.

However, all these elements do not show that a **janapada** or **territorial state** with all its attributes such as a standing army and bureaucracy had emerged in the later Vedic period but the process has started and soon after **the Vedic period in the sixth century BC** we notice the rise of **sixteen Mahajanpadas** in the northern India.

THE RIG VEDIC SOCIETY

The family was the basic unit of the Rig Vedic society. It was patriarchal in nature. Monogamy was the usual norm of marriage but the chiefs at times practiced polygamy. The family was part of a larger grouping called **vis or clan**. One or more than one clans made **jana** or **tribe**.

The jana was the largest social unit. All the members of a clan were related to each other

by blood relation. The membership of a tribe was based on birth and not on residence in a certain area. Thus the members of the **Bharata tribe** were known as the **Bharatas**. It did not imply any territory.

The Rigvedic society was a simple and largely an **egalitarian society**. There was **no rigid caste division**. Occupation was **not based on birth**. Members of a family could adopt different occupations. However certain differences did exist during the period. Varna or colour was the basis of initial differentiation between **the Vedic and non-Vedic people**.

he Rigveda mentions **arya varna and dasa varna**. Here dasa has been used in the sense of a group different from the Rigvedic people.

The **warriors, priests and the ordinary** people were the three sections of the Rigvedic tribe. The **sudra** category came into existence only towards the end of the Rigvedic period. This means that the division of society in the early Vedic period was not sharp. The women in society enjoyed respectable position. She was married at a proper age and could choose a husband of her own choice. She could take part in the proceedings of the tribal assemblies called **sabha and vidatha**. Women like Lopamudra, wife of Agastya who is believed to have composed many hymns of vedas.

SOCIAL CHANGES IN THE LATER VEDIC PHASE (1000 BC-500BC)

The family remains the basic unit of the Vedic society. However, its composition underwent a change. The later Vedic family became large enough to be called a joint-family with three or four generations living together. The rows of hearths discovered at **Atranjikhhera and at Ahichchhtra** (both in western Uttar Pradesh) show that these were meant for communal feeding or for cooking the food of large families.

The **institution of gotra** developed in this period. This means that people having common gotra descended from a common ancestor and **no marriage between the members of the same gotra** could take place.

Monogamous marriages were preferred even though polygamy was frequent. Some restrictions on women appeared during this period. In a text women have been counted as a vice along with dice and wine. In another text a daughter has been said to be the source of all sorrows. Women had to stay with her husband at his place after marriage.

The **participation of women in public meetings** was restricted. However, the most important change was the rise and growth of social differentiation in the form of **varna system**.

FOUR VARNA SYSTEM

The four varnas in which society came to be divided were the **Brahmanas, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras**. The growing number of **sacrifices and rituals** during the period made the brahmanas very powerful. They conducted various rituals including those related to different stages of **agricultural operations**. This made them all the more important. The kshatriyas, next in the social hierarchy, were the **rulers**.

They along with brahmanas controlled all aspects of life. The **vaishyas**, the most numerous **varna** were engaged in **agriculture as well as in trade and artisanal activities**. The **brahmanas** and the **kshatriyas** were dependent on the tributes (gifts and taxes) paid to them by the **vaishyas**.

The **shudras**, the fourth varna were at the bottom of the social hierarchy. They were supposed to be in the **service of the three upper varnas**. They were not entitled to the ritual of **upanayana samskara**. The other three varnas were entitled to such a ceremony

and hence they were known as **dvijas**.

This can be seen as the beginning of the imposition of disabilities on the **shudras** as well as the beginning of the concept of ritual pollution. Another important institution that began to take shape was **ashrama** or different stages of life.

Brahmacharya (student life), grihastha (householder), and vanaprastha (hermitage) stages are mentioned in the texts. Later, sanyasa, the fourth stage also came to be added. Together with **varna**, it came to be known as **varna-ashrama dharma**.

THE EARLY VEDIC RELIGION

The prayers to please gods for physical protection and for material gains were the main concerns of the Rigvedic people. The Rigvedic gods were generally **personifications of different aspects of natural forces** such as rains, storm, sun etc.

The Aryans personified the natural forces and looked upon them as living beings. The most important divinity was **Indra** who played the role of warlord (breaker of forts – Purandar, also associated with storm and thunder).

The second position was held by Agni (fire-god). He is considered as an intermediary between gods and men. **Varuna** occupied the third position. He personified water and was supposed to uphold the natural order. He was ethically the highest of all Rigvedic gods. Soma was considered to be the god of plants. Soma was both the deified ritual drink and the deity associated with it; later traditions also linked Soma with the moon and vegetation. **Maruts personified the storms**.

Some female deities are also mentioned, like Aditi and Usha, Ushas was the goddess of dawn; Aditi was associated with boundlessness, freedom and motherhood of the Adityas.

The Rigveda provides no clear evidence of temple-centred or image-based worship. Worshipped in open air through yajnas. In fact, the religion of early Vedic Aryans was primarily **of worship of nature and Yajnas**.

RELIGIOUS CHANGES IN THE LATER VEDIC PHASE (1000 BC-500BC)

Indra and Agni lost their importance. **Prajapati (the creator)** became supreme. Vishnu came to be conceived as the preserver and protector of the people. Some of the social orders came to have their own deities like Pushan, responsible for well-being of the cattle, became the god of the shudras.

Rituals and formulae became prominent in the cult of sacrifice. They brought the priestly class a large amount of wealth in form of **dana** and **dakshina**. A large number of cattle and other animals which were sacrificed at the end of each yajna must have hampered the growth of economy.

Therefore, a path of good conduct and self-sacrifice was recommended for happiness and welfare in the last sections of the Vedas, called the **Upanishads**. Upanishads contain two **basic principles of Indian philosophy** viz., **karma** and the **transmigration of soul**, i.e., rebirth based on past deeds. According to these texts real happiness lies in getting moksha i.e. freedom from this cycle of birth and re-birth.

DHARMA AND RITA

Dharma was a conception of obligations and of the discharge of one's duties to oneself and to others. Rita is the principle of **natural order which regulates and coordinates the operation of the universe** and everything within it. In the hymns of the Vedas, Rita is described as that which is ultimately responsible for the **proper functioning of the natural, moral and sacrificial orders**.

EARLY VEDIC ECONOMY

The early Vedic Aryans were **pastoralists**. Cattle rearing was their main occupation. They reared cattle, sheep, goats, and horses for purposes of milk, meat and rides. The most important form of their wealth was cow. The cows were thought of as providers of everything.

Prayers are offered for increase in the number of cattle. All the above and many more references show that **cattle breeding were the most important economic activity of the Rigvedic Aryans**. However, this is not to suggest that the early Vedic people had no knowledge of agriculture.

The evidence for agriculture in comparison with pastoral activities in the early portions is **meager** and mostly late insertions. A few references show that they had **knowledge of agriculture** and practiced it to supplement their food requirements.

They produced **yava (modern jau or barley)**, which was rather a generic word for cereals. Apart from cattle-rearing and small-scale cultivation, people were engaged in many other economic activities.

Hunting, carpentry, tanning, weaving, chariot-making, metal smeltry etc. were some such activities. The products of these activities were exchanged through barter. However, cows were the most favoured medium of exchange. The priests received cows, horses and gold ornaments as **fees for performing sacrifices**.

ECONOMIC CHANGES IN THE LATER VEDIC PHASE (1000 BC-500BC)

During later Vedic phase, **agriculture became the mainstay of the Vedic people**. Many rituals were introduced to initiate the process of agriculture. It also speaks of ploughing with yokes of six and eight oxen. The buffalo had been domesticated for the agricultural purposes. This animal was extremely useful in ploughing the swampy land. The **god Indra** acquires a new epithet '**Lord of the Plough**' in this period. The number and varieties of plant food increased.

Apart from barley, people now cultivated **wheat, rice, pulses, lentils, millet, sugarcane etc.** The items of **dana and dakshina** included cooked rice. Thus with the beginning of food production, agricultural produce began to be offered in the rituals.

The main factor in the expansion of the Aryan culture during the later Vedic period was the beginning of the use of iron around **1000 BC**. The Rigvedic people knew of a metal called **ayas** which was either copper or bronze. In the later Vedic literature **ayas** was qualified with **shyama or krishna** meaning black to denote **iron**.

Archaeology has shown that iron began to be used around 1000 BC which is also the period of later Vedic literature. The **northern and eastern parts of India** to which the Aryans later migrated receive more rainfall than the **north-western part of India**. As a result, this region is covered with thick rain forests which could not be cleared by copper or stone tools used by Rigvedic people.

The use of iron tools now helped people clear the dense rain forests particularly the huge stumps left after burning, in a more effective manner. Large tracts of forestland could be converted into cultivable pieces in relatively lesser time.

The iron plough could turn the soil from deeper portions making it more fertile. This process seems to have begun during the later part of the Rigvedic period but the effect of iron tools and implements become evident only towards the end of the Later Vedic period. There has been a continuous increase in the population during the later Vedic

period due to the expansion of the economy based on agriculture. The increasing number and size of **Painted Grey Ware (PGW)** settlements in the doab area shows this.

With the passage of time the Vedic people also acquired better knowledge of seasons, **manuring and irrigation**. All these developments resulted in the substantial enlargement of certain settlements such as **Hastinapur and Kaushambi** towards the end of the Later Vedic period. These settlements slowly began to acquire characteristics of towns. Such rudimentary towns inhabited mainly by the chiefs, princes, priests and artisans were supported by the peasants who could spare for them some part of their produce voluntarily or involuntarily.

THE VEDIC LITERATURE

THE VEDAS

The word '**veda**' is derived from the root '**vid**' i.e. to know. It is specifically applied to a branch of literature considered to be '**sruti**', i.e. sacred knowledge or divine revelation.

CONTENTS

The Vedic literature consists of **Samhitas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas and Upanishads**.

SAMHITAS

They are collections of hymns sung in the praise of various gods. They are four in number- **Rig Veda Samhita, Sama Veda Samhita, Yajur Veda Samhita and Atharva Veda Samhita**.

THE RIG VEDA

The Rig Veda, literally meaning Veda of praise, is divided into ten mandalas or books and consists of **1028 'suktas' or hymns**. It is the oldest as well as the most important of all the Samhitas. It also consists of the famous '**Gayatri mantra**' addressed to the solar deity Savitri. It is specialised by the '**hotri' invoker**) type of priest.

THE SAMA VEDA

The Sama Veda, meaning Veda of melody, consist of hymns taken from the Rig Veda and set to tune for the purpose of singing. Called the 'book of chants', it is specialised by the '**udgatri'(chanter)** type of priest. The origin of Indian music is traced to it.

THE YAJUR VEDA

The Yajur Veda, meaning of ritualistic formulas, consists of various '**mantras**' and rules to be observed at the time of sacrifice. Specialised by the '**adhvaryu' (performer)** type of priest, it has the origin of Indian rituals. It also has the **earliest Indian prose- writing**.

THE ATHARVA VEDA

The Atharva Veda, meaning Veda of magic formulas, contains charms and spells to ward off evils and diseases. Believed to be work of non- Aryans, its contents throw light on the beliefs and practices of the non- Aryans. It also has the origin of Indian medicine.

BRAHMANAS

They explain the hymns of the vedas and propagate the '**karmamarga**' (path of deeds). The important Brahmanas are **Aitareya, Kausitaki, Tandyamaha, Taiminiya, Taittiriya, Satapatha and gopatha Brahmanas**. They are written in prose and they elaborately describe the various sacrifices and rituals, along with their mystic meanings.

Each veda has several Brahmanas attached to it.

1. **Rigveda:** Kaushetki and Aitreya.
2. **Yajurveda:** Taitriya & Shatpatha.
3. **Samveda:** Panchvish & Jemineya.
4. **Atharvaveda :** Gopath.

The most important is 'Shatapatha Brahmana' attached to Yajurveda, which is most

exhaustive and important of all. Brahmana of one hundred paths/chapters

THE ARANYAKA

The word **Aranyaka** means '**the forest**' and these are called '**forest books**' written mainly for the hermits and students living in the jungles. These are the concluding portions of the Brahmanas or their appendices.

They deal with **mysticism and symbolism**. They form the **natural transition of the Upanishads**. They offer the bridge between **Karma marga** (way of deeds) which was the sole concern of the Brahmanas and the **jnana marga** (way of knowledge) which the **Upanishads** advocated.

UPANISHADS

They are philosophical texts. Being critical of the rituals and sacrifices, they lay stress on the '**jnanamarga**' (path of knowledge). The central theme of their metaphysics is '**tat tvam asi**, i.e. the unity of the '**brahman**' (supreme being or soul) and the '**atman**' (individual soul), found in the **Chandogya** Upanishad. Of the several Upanishads, only twelve are very important. Among the twelve also only the **Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya Upanishads** are the oldest. (The famous dialogue between Nachiketa and Yama is mentioned in the **Kathopanishad**).

The word Upanishad has been derived from the root **Upani-sad** that means '**to sit down near someone**'. It denotes a student sitting under the feet of his guru to learn. Eventually the word began to be used for the **secret knowledge** imparted by the guru to his selected pupils. They profess the goal of life to be to attain **moksha (salvation)** which is possible through **meditation and self-control**. They also condemn the ceremonies and the sacrifices. They discuss the various theories of creation of the universe and define the doctrine of action (Karma).

VEDANGAS

There are six **Vedangas**: (a) **Shiksha (phonetics)**, (b) **Kalpa (rituals)**, (c) **Vyakarna (grammar)**, (d) **Nirukta (etymology)**, (e) **Chandas (metrics)** and (f) **Jyotisha (astronomy)**. The Vedangas are called '**smriti**' or literature handed down by tradition.

SUTRA LITERATURE

They are written in the form of '**sutras**' i.e. **condensed prose style**. Of all the '**sutra**' texts, **Kalpa Sutras** again divided into three classes: (i) **Srauta Sutras**, (ii) **Grihya Sutras** and (iii) **Dharma Sutras**. **Sulva Sutras**, the oldest books on Indian geometry, are found within the Srauta Sutras. It is the third one with which the historians are mainly concerned, for it constitutes the foundation of the **Dharmasastras** such as the **Laws of Manu**.

UPA VEDAS

Four Minor Vedas came to be written on the basis of the Vedic literature. They are **Ayur Veda (medicine)**, **Silpa veda (sculpture)**, **Gandharva Veda (music)** and **Dhanur Veda (warfare)**.

COMPARISON BETWEEN INDUS CIVILISATION AND VEDIC AGE

Aspect	Indus Civilisation	Vedic Age
Major Sources	Archaeological (seals, excavations, artefacts)	Vedas (literary sources)
Language	Uncertainty : Indus script undeciphered	Indo-European
Script	Pictographic	Oral tradition first; later written

Nature of Life	Urban and agrarian	Migratory and pastoral (RVP) Settled and agrarian (LVP)
Polity	Efficient and centralised	Tribal polity to monarchies
AGRICULTURE		
Chief Crops	Wheat and barley	Wheat and barley
Rice	Only in Gujarat (Rangpur, Lothal)	Only in the LVP
Cotton	Pioneers	Only in the LVP
Ploughing	Known	Practised
ANIMALS		
Cow	No appearance in seals	Important
Horse	-----	Widespread use
Tiger	Known	Unknown in RVP
Lion	Unknown	Known
MATERIAL CULTURE		
Pottery	Wheeled and painted ware	Painted Grey Ware (PGW)
Houses	Use of burnt bricks	Made of mud-walls only in LVP
Expansion	No attempt	Rapid expansion
SOCIETY		
Social Division	Occupational division	Occupational division in RVP Varna-based division in LVP
Position of Women	Good status	Good in RVP when compared to LVP
TRADE		
Trade	long-distance trade with Mesopotamia and Central Asia;	Unimportant in RVP Expanded; references to seas and sea voyages in LVP
RELIGION		
Chief Deities	Pasupati Mahadeva	RVP : Indra and Agni LVP : Prajapati, Vishnu and Rudra
Linga and Yoni	Widespread	No evidence
Mode of Worship	Prayers	RVP : Prayers and sacrifices LVP : Sacrifices and rituals

PREVIOUS YEARS' QUESTIONS (PRELIMS)

1. Which of the following pairs of ancient and modern names of rivers is/are correctly matched ? (2026)
 1. Vitasta : Chenab
 2. Asikni : Jhelum
 3. Parushni : Ravi
 4. Yavyavati : Beas

Select the answer using the code given below :

 - (a) 1 and 2
 - (b) 3 and 4
 - (c) 3 only
 - (d) 4 only

2. Consider the following statements about the Rigvedic period : (2026)
 - I. Irrigation from wells allowed agriculture to expand away from flood plains and strips on river margins into the present Punjab and Haryana plains having underground water levels reasonably close to the surface.
 - II. Draught-animal power was employed to draw up water out of the wells.

Which of the following information support/supports the above statements?

 1. There is evidence in the Rigveda of the use of ashma chakra (stone pulley wheel) and ahava (strapped wooden pails) to draw up water.
 2. Mention has been made in the Rigveda of the use of implements like parashu / kulisha (axe) and datra / sreni (sickle).
 3. There is a history of the use of ox, even before the Rigveda, for ploughing the land and pulling the carts.

Select the answer using the code given below:

 - (a) 1 and 2 only
 - (b) 1, 2 and 3
 - (c) 1 and 3 only
 - (d) 3 only

3. Consider the following statements: (2024)
 1. There are no parables in Upanishads.
 2. Upanishads were composed earlier than the Puranas.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

 - (a) 1 only
 - (b) 2 only
 - (c) Both 1 and 2
 - (d) Neither 1 nor 2

4. With reference to the difference between the culture of Rigvedic Aryans and Indus Valley people, which of the following statements is/are correct? (2017)
 1. Rigvedic Aryans used the coat of mail and helmet in warfare whereas the people of Indus Valley Civilization did not leave any evidence of using them.
 2. Rigvedic Aryans knew gold, silver and copper whereas Indus Valley people knew only copper and iron.
 3. Rigvedic Aryans had domesticated the horse whereas there is no evidence of Indus Valley people having been aware of this animal.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

 - (a) 1 only
 - (b) 2 and 3 only
 - (c) 1 and 3 only
 - (d) 1, 2 and 3

5. Which one of the following pairs does not form part of the six systems of Indian Philosophy? (2014)
 - (a) Mimamsa and Vedanta
 - (b) Nyaya and vaisheshika
 - (c) Lokayata and kapalika

- (d) Sankhya and Yoga
6. The national motto of India, 'Satyameva Jayate' inscribed below the Emblem of India is taken from **(2014)**
 (a) Katha Upanishad
 (b) Chandogya Upanishad
 (c) Aitareya Upanishad
 (d) Mundaka Upanishad
7. With reference to the history of philosophical thought in India, consider the following statements regarding Sankhya school: **(2013)**
 1. Sankhya does not accept the theory of rebirth or transmigration of soul.
 2. Sankhya holds it is the self-knowledge that leads to liberation and not any exterior influence or agent.
 Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
 (a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
8. The religion of early Vedic Aryans was primarily of **(2012)**
 (a) Bhakti (b) Image worship and Yajnas
 (c) Worship of nature and Yajnas (d) Worship of nature and Bhakti
9. The "dharma" and "rita" depict a central idea of ancient Vedic civilization of Indian. In this context consider the following statements: **(2011)**
 1. Dharma was a conception of obligations and of the discharge of one's duties to oneself and to others.
 2. Rita was the fundamental moral law governing the functioning of the universe and all it contained
 Which of the statements given is/are correct?
 (a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
10. Which one of the following four Vedas contains an account of magical charms and spells? **(2004)**
 (a) Rig -veda (b) Yajur-veda
 (c) Atharva-veda (d) Sama-veda
11. The famous dialogue between Nachiketa and Yama is mentioned in the **(1997)**
 (a) Chhandogya Upanishad (b) Mundakopanishad
 (c) Kathopanishad (d) Kenopanishad
12. The river most mentioned in early Vedic literature is **(1996)**
 (a) Sindhu (b) Sutudri (c) Saraswati (d) Ganga
13. The people of later Vedic period did not know? **(1995)**
 (a) Writing (b) Agriculture (c) Sacrifice (d) Brick making
14. Who among the following was a Brahnavadini who composed some hymns of the Vedas? **(1995)**
 (a) Lopamudra (b) Gargi (c) Leelavati (d) Savitri
15. According to Mimamsa system of philosophy liberation is possible by means of **(1995)**
 (a) Jnana (b) bhakti (c) yoga (d) karma

PYQ (MAINS)

1. Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (Answer in 150 words) 2024
2. What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (Answer in 250 words) 15 2023